

THE FIX for Cravings — Session 1: Understanding and Rewiring Cravings — 20 min

Video File Bonus2-Fix-Session1.mp4 (brain rewiring animation; swap recipe demos) · **Resources** Cravings Fix Workbook.pdf (Session 1 pages: craving map, two strategies, book prompts) · **Xp** 10 · Note 2 strategies and apply one this week (journal upload)

Target runtime 20 min · 1,741 spoken words · ≈ 11.6 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 12.9 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera, close.]

I've spent a large part of my life inside a craving. Not thinking about one, inside one: the pull, the bargaining, the moment of giving in, the shame that followed and set up the next one. So when I say that cravings can be rewired, I'm not offering a theory. I'm describing the road I walked, and then studied, and then spent more than two decades helping other people walk. THE FIX is that road, in three sessions. This is the first: what a craving actually is, and how the brain that makes it can be taught something new.

0:30–5:30 **SCIENCE: THE NEUROLOGICAL "FIX"**

[VISUAL: Brain rewiring animation: the reward pathway lights up; a worn path in a field; then a new path being walked in beside it.]

Let's start where Module One started and go deeper. A craving is the output of a learning system. Nora Volkow's group at the

National Institute on Drug Abuse described in Trends in Cognitive Sciences how highly palatable food engages the same dopamine circuitry that drugs of abuse engage: not identically, but through the same wanting system, the one whose job is to mark things as worth repeating. Every time sugar arrives after a cue, that circuit strengthens the link between cue and craving. Over years, the link becomes a groove, and the groove is what you feel at nine o'clock at night.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Eating addiction: the behavior, not just the food (Hebebrand et al., Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews)."]

Is it addiction? The honest answer is that the research is still arguing, and I find the argument useful. A review in Neuroscience and Biobehavioral Reviews by Johannes Hebebrand and colleagues proposed that what we're seeing is better described as eating addiction than food addiction: it's the pattern of behavior around eating, the loss of control, the continued use despite consequences, that mirrors addiction, more than any single substance. Ashley Gearhardt's work at Yale, which produced the Yale Food Addiction Scale published in the journal Appetite, found that a meaningful

minority of people meet addiction-like criteria for their relationship with certain foods, overwhelmingly the highly processed, high-sugar, high-fat ones. I trained in this field; I've worked as a food addiction professional for years. And I'll tell you what that training taught me: whether you call it addiction or habit, the brain mechanism is the same, and so is the way out.

[VISUAL: Slide: "The high-glycemic rebound (Lennerz et al., AJCN)."]

Then the physical half, which people underestimate. David Ludwig's milkshake study, in the American Journal of Clinical Nutrition: two shakes, same calories, different glycemic index; four hours later the high-glycemic one had produced lower blood sugar, more hunger, and more activity in the craving center. The physical craving is a rebound from the last sugar, scheduled hours in advance. So a craving has two roots. An emotional root, in the wanting circuit that learned sugar means relief. And a physical root, in the blood-sugar swing that the last sugar set up. Root causes, emotional and physical. THE FIX works on both, because working on one leaves the other running.

[VISUAL: Animation: the new path in the field becoming worn as the old one grasses over.]

And here's the hopeful science. The same plasticity that built the groove can build a new one. Every time a cue arrives and you respond differently, the tea, the walk, the pause, and it works, the brain marks the new response as worth repeating. Lally's habit research says that takes weeks of repetition, not days. Rewiring is not a decision. It's a practice, and it's the same practice for everyone: notice the cue, choose the new response, celebrate that it worked, repeat.

Let me say what "worked" means, because it's not what people expect. The new response worked if the wave passed without the sugar, or if the sugar came later and smaller, or even if you ate the thing but noticed the whole sequence for the first time. Each of those is a repetition on the new path. What doesn't count as a repetition is the old story: "I failed again." That story walks the old groove one more time. So the celebration, the small "yes," is for the noticing and the choosing, whatever the plate looked like at the end. This is the part of my training as a food addiction professional that surprised me most: recovery is measured in repetitions, not in perfect days.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Strategy 1: the pause, and the wave."]

Strategy one: the mindful pause, and I mean a specific one. When the craving arrives, before anything else, you say, out loud if you can, "there it is." Naming it. Module Four taught us why: labeling an emotion calms the brain's alarm center. Then you set a timer for ten minutes, and you do one thing that occupies your hands: the craving-buster tea, a glass of water, three physiological sighs, a text to your person. Alan Marlatt called this urge surfing: the craving rises, crests, and falls, usually within twenty minutes, and the pause is how you stay on the board. You are allowed to have the thing after the timer. Most of the time, after the timer, you won't want it, and that's the brain learning.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Strategy 2: the swap that fixes the root."]

Strategy two: the nutrient swap, built on Module Two but sharper. The physical root of a craving is a blood-sugar swing, so the swap has to remove the swing, not just replace the sweet. The rule is protein, fat, fiber, every time, and especially at the meal before your craving hour. If your craving is at three p.m., the fix is at noon: a lunch with protein

and fat. If it's at nine p.m., the fix is at dinner, and it's the after-dinner walk. And the swap for the moment itself is the one you learned: berries and walnuts, dark chocolate and almonds, apple and nut butter. Sweet, with the protein and fat that stop the rebound. Never sweet alone. Never.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Strategy 3: change the cue, not yourself."]

Strategy three: rearrange the cues. The wanting circuit fires on cues: the drawer, the drive, the show, the hour. Boswell and Kober's meta-analysis in Obesity Reviews showed cue reactivity predicts eating better than hunger does. So: the sweets out of sight. The show that came with the snack, watched somewhere else, or with tea in your hand from the first minute. The drive rerouted for two weeks. Every cue you remove is a groove you stop walking.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Strategy 4: sleep, because a tired brain craves."]

Strategy four: protect sleep. Matthew Walker's lab found a single short night increased the brain's desire for high-calorie food and weakened the regions that make careful choices. The nine p.m. craving was scheduled by the five a.m. alarm. This is the strategy people skip because it doesn't feel like a craving strategy. It's the one that changes the most.

Strategy five, and it's the deepest: address the emotional root. When the craving is about the hour after the hard conversation, or the quiet after everyone is asleep, no swap will fix it, because the craving isn't for sugar. It's for relief, or comfort, or company, or rest. So the practice is the question from Module Two, asked honestly: what do I actually need right now? And then, this is the fix, giving yourself the real thing. Rest, if it's rest. A call, if it's company. The journal, if it's something unprocessed. Sugar is the fastest answer to every one of those needs and the worst, and the brain will keep offering it until you've shown it, repeatedly, that there's a better one.

I'll add a word about shame, because it's the emotional root under the emotional root. Many people who came to this course have years of shame around food, and shame is itself a craving trigger: it feels unbearable, the brain reaches for relief, relief is sugar, and the sugar makes more shame. Module One's grace-over-guilt wasn't sentiment; it was the fix for this loop. The research on self-compassion after a lapse, Adams and Leary's study, showed that kindness reduced

further eating and criticism increased it. So the strategy for the shame root is specific: after a slip, one kind sentence, out loud, "of course I reached for that, I was exhausted," and then the next scheduled thing. Kindness is not indulgence here. It's neurochemistry.

[DEMO: Swap recipe demo: Cynthia makes the "fix bowl": plain Greek yogurt, berries, walnuts, cinnamon, a square of dark chocolate shaved on top.]

Let me make the swap I reach for most. Plain whole-milk Greek yogurt, a handful of frozen berries, a handful of walnuts, cinnamon, and a square of dark chocolate grated over the top. Ninety seconds. Protein, fat, fiber, and sweet, in that order of importance. Eat it slowly with the mindful first bite. This is what nine o'clock looks like at my house.

[VISUAL: Slide: "For fertility: clarity."]

Why this matters for conception, in one breath: stable blood sugar means stable insulin, which we've traced to ovulation and to sperm quality across this whole course. And a mind not spending its evenings bargaining with a pantry is a mind with room for the person beside you. THE FIX is about root causes, emotional and physical, for fertility clarity.

For men watching, and I hope you are: everything here applies to you, and the physical root may apply more, because men are less likely to have ever tracked a craving and more likely to have a daily sweet drink, which the Epidemiology study linked to lower monthly odds for both partners. The same two roots, the same five strategies, and the same swap. And the sleep strategy is yours especially, since testosterone and sperm are built overnight. If you do one thing from this session, make it the pause with a glass of water, and notice how often the craving was thirst.

15:30–18:30 BOOK TIE-IN

[VISUAL: Slide: "The Craving Cure by Julia Ross · and Cynthia's own writing on cravings."]

If you want to go further on the physical root, Julia Ross's *The Craving Cure* is a book I recommend to people who want a nutritional framework for cravings; her craving-type questionnaire near the start of the book is a useful lens on which of the emotional and physical roots is running your evenings, and the workbook has prompts for reading it alongside this session. One caution, as always: her supplement protocols go to your doctor before they go in your

cart. I'll also point you to my own writing on cravings, which is the long version of everything in these three sessions.

[DIRECTION: Cynthia names her own book title(s) on camera; links appear in the video description and on the resources slide.]

18:30–19:30 **Q&A TEASER AND HEART-LED CLOSE**

[VISUAL: Slide: "Post your questions in the forum for Session 3."]

Session Three ends with a Q&A, and I'd like it to be yours. Post your questions in the forum, the ones you've never asked anyone, about the evening craving, the travel craving, the craving that comes with the negative test, and I'll answer as many as I can. As someone who has walked my own road with cravings, I promise you nothing you post will surprise me, and nothing will be judged.

19:30–20:00 **ACTION HANDOFF**

[VISUAL: End card: "Cravings Fix Workbook → Note 2 strategies, apply one this week (journal upload, 10 XP)."]

Open the Cravings Fix Workbook, note the two strategies that fit your roots, and apply one this week; upload a journal entry about how it went for ten XP. Session Two is the practical toolkit, and I'll be making a smoothie.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Cravings Fix Workbook.pdf, Session 1 pages (craving map by root, five strategies, "what do I actually need?" page, book prompts). **ACTION 1:** Note two strategies and apply one this week; upload a journal entry (10 XP). **NEXT STEP: THE FIX Session 2**
· Practical Craving Busters.

Session 1 can be recorded as a live call or a studio video. The Q&A teaser at the end invites viewers to post questions in the forum for Session 3.